

TB Tape

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Overview

Slows audio to silence and spins it back to normal speed with a motor curve you can draw yourself.

What this plug-in solves

TB Tape creates repeatable tape-stop and restart transitions without drawing detailed clip-speed automation. Braking and spin-up can use different timing, while one reusable Motor Curve defines the character of both directions.

What you can expect

- Tape-style slowdown all the way to silence
- Independent braking and restart timing
- Freehand and point-based curve editing
- Six musical curve shortcuts plus user preset recall

How it works

TB Tape reads a short recent history of the input at a changing speed. Because playback rate controls both speed and pitch, Pause falls naturally toward silence and Play rises back toward normal speed instead of applying a separate pitch effect.

Stop Time and Start Time set the duration of each direction. One Motor Curve shapes both transitions, with the restart using the corresponding reversed motion. The curve is captured when a transition begins, so an edit made during movement is heard after the next Play or Pause trigger.

Quick start

- 1** Start from Init and set Stop Time and Start Time for the musical event.
- 2** Choose the curve shortcut closest to the intended movement.
- 3** Trigger Play / Pause while a short section repeats and listen to where the speed change feels strongest.
- 4** Use Draw or Points to refine the curve, then retrigger because edits are applied to the next transition.
- 5** Compare with Bypass, check the landing point in the full arrangement, and save the result as a user preset when needed.

Interface and key sections



This is a direct capture of the current plug-in interface. Use the visible labels to locate the areas and controls explained below.

Play / Pause

Pause brakes the virtual motor until speed and pitch reach silence; Play spins it back to normal speed. Changing direction during a transition continues from the current motor speed instead of jumping to a new position.

Stop Time and Start Time

Stop Time sets the length of the slowdown and Start Time sets the length of the return. Use them independently for a fast brake with a slow restart, a long coast with a quick recovery, or symmetrical movement.

One shared Motor Curve

The same curve shapes both directions: the stop follows it toward silence and the restart follows its time-reversed counterpart toward normal speed. The curve is captured when a transition begins, so edits made during motion are heard on the next Play or Pause trigger.

Draw mode

Drag freely across the graph to sketch the motor motion over time. Double-click the graph to restore a Linear curve. The fixed first and last positions keep the transition connected to complete stop and normal playback.

Points mode

Drag an interior node to refine the curve. Double-click empty graph space to add a node, or double-click an interior node to remove it. The first and last points cannot be moved or deleted.

Curve shortcuts

Linear moves evenly; S-Curve eases both ends; Slow In delays the strongest movement; Fast In places it early; Stepped creates deliberate jumps; Motor Drag emphasizes a heavy late brake or spin. Any manual edit changes the curve label to Custom.

Motion feedback

The green playhead shows progress through the current transition and the reel animation follows motor speed. Both are visual indicators rather than controls.

TB TAPE preset menu

Open the center nameplate to see the current preset, Previous and Next navigation, Factory and User collections, Save User Preset, Undo, and Redo. Factory programs include Init, Quick Brake, Soft Brake, Slow Spin-Up, Instant Motor, Long Coast, Late Drop, and Early Brake.

Preset and session state

User presets retain the timing controls and complete custom curve. The DAW session also restores them, so a drawn motion can be reused without rebuilding it. DAW automation can select a Factory program, while the individual curve points are not separate automation lanes.

Bypass

Bypass returns the aligned dry signal for comparison. It is separate from Play / Pause: bypassing does not request a tape stop, and pausing does not bypass the plug-in.

Controllable properties

The guide uses the names shown on the plug-in panel. Each explanation describes the audible result, a useful way to approach the control, and an important interaction to listen for.

Control	What it does and when to use it
Bypass	Turns the complete effect off or on for a direct before-and-after comparison. Compare with bypass at a similar loudness, and let the active stop or start transition finish before judging the difference.
Play	Requests normal playback or starts the tape-motor slowdown when switched to Pause. Trigger it on a clear musical event and leave enough time for the selected stop or start transition to finish.
Program	Loads a factory starting point. Adjust the controls afterward to fit the current sound. Use a preset as a direction, not a finished answer. Change one control at a time so it is clear which adjustment improves the source.
Start Time	Sets how long the tape motor takes to accelerate from silence to normal speed. Trigger Play early enough that normal speed returns at the intended musical point.
Stop Time	Sets how long the tape motor takes to slow from normal speed to silence. Loop the transition and set the braking length before refining the Motor Curve.

Motor Curve, Draw, Points, the six curve shortcuts, the preset menu, and the motion indicators are panel functions rather than separate automation rows. They are explained individually in the interface section, and the complete custom curve is stored with presets and the DAW session.

Practical uses

End-of-section tape stop

- Set Stop Time and choose Linear or Motor Drag.
- Automate Play to Pause on the final beat.
- Leave enough time for the motor to reach silence.

Expected result: Pitch and speed fall to a clean stop without clip automation.

Slow restart

- Choose a longer Start Time than Stop Time.
- Use S-Curve or draw a gentle lower half.
- Press Play before the next phrase and place the trigger early enough for full-speed recovery.

Expected result: The source spins back up gradually and reaches normal speed at the intended musical point.

Custom motor contour

- Use Draw or Points to create one controlled rise and dip inside the curve.
- Retrigg the transition after editing so the new latched curve is heard.
- Audition on sustained material before using the same motion on drums or a full mix.

Expected result: The transition follows a repeatable custom speed path without adding delay repeats or saturation.

Hard rhythmic edit

- Choose Instant Motor or begin with a very short transition.
- Place the Play / Pause edge exactly on the desired beat.
- If the jump becomes distracting, lengthen the time or soften the first curve corner.

Expected result: The source makes an abrupt speed cut that behaves like a designed rhythmic edit.

Reusable transition preset

- Build the timing and curve on a clear sustained source.
- Open the TB TAPE menu and save a User preset.
- Recall it on another source and adjust only the timing needed for the new arrangement.

Expected result: A recognizable motor gesture can be reused while still fitting the timing of each song or sound.

Common pitfalls

The effect is Tape Stop, not Tape Delay; it does not create repeats, feedback, saturation, wow, flutter, hiss, reverse audio, or tempo-synchronized movement. Use Play/Pause and the motor timing controls for transitions; use a separate delay when repeats are required.

Very short times, Stepped, and abrupt custom corners can create intentionally hard pitch jumps or click-like edges. Lengthen the transition or smooth the nearby curve values before changing the rest of the sound.

Curve changes made during motion are intentionally reserved for the next transition. Finish the edit, trigger the transition again, and judge the complete motion from its beginning.

A long paused hold is not an unlimited frozen recording; restart returns toward the current live input and then settles back into sync. Plan the restart around the material currently reaching the plug-in rather than expecting earlier paused audio to play back.

Active and bypassed playback rely on the DAW's delay compensation to remain aligned. Compare inside the same compensated signal path and keep the DAW's delay compensation active.